PO11Q - Quantitative Political Analysis: From Measurement to Inference

Sample Paragraph for the Report



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In the following text, note the structure:

- Statement of the argument / the thesis
- Explanation of what the thesis means
- Evidence to support the thesis, drawing on examples for both positions
- A concluding sentence
- Please also note how easy it is to get to 12 unique references in 400 words

There is considerable disagreement in the literature whether democracy should be regarded as a binary, or a continuous concept. In a binary conception, a country is either democratic or not, while in a continuous conception, countries can be more or less democratic. Advocates of the binary conceptualisation argue that that there is a set of minimum criteria that define a threshold at which a democracy ceases to be (see Przeworski et al., 2000, Chapter 1; Miller et al., 2022). Relatedly, Sartori argues that democracy is a “bounded whole”: a political system whose defining features hang together as a system, so that a regime either has them or does not (see Sartori, 1987). On this view, democracy and non-democracy differ in kind rather than in degree, and we must first establish whether a country is a democracy before we can meaningfully ask how democratic it is. Treating democracy as a matter of degree from the outset is, for Sartori, a conceptual error that he calls “degreeism” (Sartori, 1991, p. 248). Yet, it is precisely the need for degreeism that underpins the position of advocates for a continuous conceptualisation of democracy. Here, the argument is that it is not only meaningful to speak of more or less democratic countries [see Dahl (1971), p. 8; Dahl (1989), pp. 241, 316-317; and Coppedge, Michael and Reinicke, Wolfgang H. (1990), but that it is indeed necessary to measure democracy on a continuous scale to avoid losing information (Bollen & Jackman, 1989). Otherwise, countries that differ meaningfully in how democratic they are may be erroneously grouped together, which leads to measurement error and misleading results (see also Elkins, 2000). Interestingly, Przeworski et al. (2000) are able to show, however, that binary indexes in fact carry a lower level of error than continuous ones (see Przeworski et al., 2000, Appendix 1.1.). The authors also show that most polychotomous scales form a distinct U-pattern, pointing to a natural binary distribution: empirically, countries are either very democratic or very undemocratic, with few countries in between (see Przeworski et al., 2000, p. 59). Overall, the disagreement in the literature remains unresolved and a plethora of different democracy indexes have been developed and remain in use today (see Cheibub et al., 2010; Miller et al., 2022; Przeworski et al., 2000; as examples for dichotomous indexes and Marshall & Gurr, 2020; Coppedge et al., 2025, as examples for continuous indexes).

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